



MARSH ARABS

MAKING THE MOST OF THE

ENVIRONMENT

IN A REGION KNOWN FOR its deserts, artificial islands scattered throughout the marshlands of Iraq are home to the Ma'dan, or Marsh Arabs. The Ma'dan are accomplished canoeists and experts at utilizing this environment, which they have inhabited for over 5,000 years. They build islands and homes from marsh reeds, grow rice in the marsh water, and catch fish for food and trade. Perhaps most importantly, the marsh provides ideal grazing for the buffalo, a family's

most prized possession. A

buffalo supplies dung for fuel

and milk for dairy

produce, which is eaten or traded for wheat to make bread.

Buffalos are rarely eaten, and are so cherished that an owner will even sing to soothe a sick animal.

